in a year. After the Worlds, within 60 days, Chopra will defend the two other international titles he holds, as the Commonwealth Games (CWG) and Asian Games (AG) champion. He had the option to peak at the Worlds and then opt out of at least one of the other big Games, but chose not to. "I am an athlete, my job is to work," he said to me, even when awash in his celebratory post-Tokyo cascade.

What 2022 expects of that work is Neeraj 2.2—an updated, improved version of himself. By beating his personal best (88.07 metre), scaling the elusive 90 metre mark and going mano a mano with his sport's current giant Johannes Vetter, who crosses 90 metres like jaywalkers do streets. Chopra stepped off the conveyer belt of felicitations as late as the first week of December, leaving India for the sanity of a training base overseas. He is now in the US. And while 2022 may be a hell of a stretch, flexibility happens to be one of his biggest strengths.

For all our athletes across sports, 2022 demands rebooting, revival and resurgence at a rapid pace they will not be used to. In a pre-Covid age, the 12 months after an Olympics was usually a gap year, when they took a breath, re-oriented plans, sort out kinks in fitness before the push for the CWG-AG double blast. Except a delayed Olympics nixed the gap year and set everything on turbo.

Memories of Tokyo are fresh, so slacking off is not an option: those who came through shining, will get called out for continuing to hide behind its lustre. For those who didn't quite cut it at the Olympics, 2022 can stoke belief again. Particularly the shooters whose CWG medal binges are no longer possible as the sport itself has been erased from the CWG programme. The AG offer far tougher fields and will be followed by the World Shooting Championships. The place occupied by shooting, the country's pre-eminent sport (outside of cricket), has been emphatically replaced by Chopra, badminton and hockey. It is why 2022 is shooting's opportunity to regain lost ground and goodwill.

The year offers a renewed focus on another sport, football, with the staging of two major events—the AFC Women's Asian Cup and FIFA u-17 women's football world cup. Removed from the hoopla, our football's preference for its top-down, big-event governance needs ruthless scrutiny. Their gossamer model bypasses the need to see working boots into the grassroots offering millions of boys and girls competitive, local, state and national leagues over the decoy of 'exposure' and 'prep' tours for a few dozen elite players picked for a showpiece event.

Over the year, the ascent of Odisha as the new hub for Indian sport (again, outside cricket) will only be confirmed. In a March 2021 Grant Thornton survey of Sports Cities of India, Bhubaneswar was No. 3 behind Delhi and Mumbai and was followed by Bengaluru and Ahmedabad. The published survey somehow featured Bhubaneswar at No.4, behind Ahmedabad and Bengaluru, but typos aside, Odisha's sporting profile has displaced other sporting strongholds. The state putting its money where its mouth is, in the case of sponsorships of national hockey teams, did not go unnoticed either following the successes of the hockey campaigns in Tokyo. There's a 20,000 seater hockey stadium being built in Rourkela for the Hockey World Cup that will be staged there in January 2023.

Finally, front and centre, occupying the top of the mind is the great gorilla—cricket. In 2022, a churn is going to come, with a 10-team IPL set in motion. The IPL's 15th season will mark the next phase of its reinvention, both in the national men's team and its imprint on the global calendar. Trends indicate the men's team will be split into two clear components—red ball and white ball squads—under different captains. It won't be the first time India will have had two captains for separate formats, but this time will be a hard-nosed cleaving. In the past, the Kumble-Dhoni or Dhoni-Kohli formula was merely a stopgap until one was given all three jobs.

Kohli, 33, is in the latter half of his career and trying to re-discover his batting mojo with some parts of his captaincy portfolio expendable. India's tri-format players and, by extension, captaincy candidates at the moment are only a handful: Rohit Sharma, 34, Mohammed Shami 31, K.L. Rahul 29, Jasprit Bumrah 28 and Rishabh Pant, 24. The new year will bring yet another piece of ICC silverware for the taking in the ICC Men's T20 World Cup in Australia. Kohli has ensured it will not be his captaincy cross to bear and whoever is chosen will write the team's future script.

But much before IPL begins, there is more disruption due in the first quarter of 2022: in case the UAE cricket's six-team, 34-match T20 league gets off the ground. The Glazers of Manchester United have confirmed their franchise acquisition with UAE cricket and at least two Indian T20 franchises have indicated interest in fielding teams—the already multi-national Knight Riders and the Reliance-owned behemoths Mumbai Indians. Should both get involved, well, that will change everything. ■

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